reflection, they strategically avoid closure on matters of history and democracy.

Together, through historical engagement with the period of the Berlin Wall and excursions through its monumental afterlife, the on-site explorations of the divided city and the Berlin Wall by Freed, Davis, Tajiri, and Lorde prompted reflections then, as they do now, on the complexities and fault lines of America's democratic project. Such reflections grappled with Cold War policies and practices and, when read today, continue to spark engagement with American global politics and the shared physical and symbolic character of border walls, as a matter of navigating our own political landscapes of division. Rather than seeking Berlin as a site in which freedom and repression are to be imagined as distinct formations, historically or geographically, the reader is invited to approach the city as a means of understanding the dialectical relationship between freedom and repression as interlinked. In other words, this book aims to unseat the relative ease with which American culture currently incorporates the Berlin Wall into its own history of progress without further reflection on our own lines of division—whether physically or socially inscribed, historically relevant, or newly emergent since 1989. My hope is to spotlight the enduring and urgent role of the artist, writer, or activist as a civic actor. Cultural agents meaningfully task themselves and the rest of us with weighing American practices of freedom, moving in and out of U.S. borders and internal sites of division, critically exploring zones of conflict, and mapping the gaps between the nation's democratic ideals and lived realities.

The Berlin Wall emerged as a site integral to and symbolic of the Cold War cultural imagination in the United States, but only in retrospect can we discern how integral the stories of struggle by the Wall are intertwined both with those of its triumphant dismantling and with our current failures to imagine a world without pernicious lines of division. The Berlin Wall continues to signify on this cyclical history, especially as leaders and state actors—responsible for the fortifications and inhumane detention policies along the U.S.-Mexico border, the apartheid walls separating Israel from Palestine, the fences built to hinder refugees crossing into southern countries of the European Union, and the sites of climate and ecological violence, among countless other barriers—fail to learn crucial lessons from the profound violence and ignorance of bygone wall builders. The chants to